

QUEEN OF SPAIN Born 1451 Died 1504

Isabella of Castile

“I... am ready to **pawn my jewels** to defray the expenses of it...”

ISABELLA TO COLUMBUS, SPEAKING ABOUT HIS PROPOSED VOYAGE TO ASIA, 1492

According to a contemporary chronicler, Isabella I of Spain was a neglected child: “The Queen, Our Lady, from childhood was without a father and we can even say a mother... She had work and cares, and an extreme lack of necessary things.” Isabella’s father, John II of Castile (a Spanish kingdom), died when she was three, at which point her depressed mother shut herself away. Her young brother died of a plaguelike illness in 1468, and her older half-brother, the mentally unstable Henry IV, perceived her as a threat. However, Isabella emerged from this Cinderella-like childhood an extremely strong-willed and intelligent young woman.

As a leading contender for the throne of Castile, Isabella attracted many suitors—including the king of Portugal and brothers of the kings of England and France—but she herself decided to marry Ferdinand of Aragon: “It has to be he and absolutely no other.” In marrying the young prince of Aragon—whom she had yet to meet—17-year-old Isabella

risked the wrath of Henry, who had not given his consent. But Isabella knew that this was the marriage most likely to bring her power. In 1469 they were married in the Spanish city of Valladolid, and for much of the next 10 years they fought for recognition of their right to become joint rulers of the unruly kingdom of Castile.

Love and war

In 1474 Henry died and civil war broke out. However, within a few years it was clear that Isabella and Ferdinand were winning on every front. By 1476 they had set up the *hermandad* (“brotherhood”), a network of local



Catholic New World

This 17th-century altarpiece from Guatemala reveals the impact of Spanish culture in the Americas. Isabella regarded it as her sacred duty to bring Christianity to her subjects in the New World.



Isabella the Catholic

Isabella’s strong will helped bring about fundamental changes in Spain. Her reign led to the permanent unification of Spain (which had previously been a collection of kingdoms) and her decision to sponsor Christopher Columbus’s journey to find a new route to Asia laid the groundwork for an era of global commerce and trade.